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To cite this article: Louise Timlin, Ana Catalano Weeks & Anna Helgøy (07 Jul 2026): How can we improve gender balance in local government? Family-friendly policies and static ambition in England, Journal of European Public Policy, DOI: [10.1080/13501763.2026.2699357](https://doi.org/10.1080/13501763.2026.2699357)

To link to this article: <https://doi.org/10.1080/13501763.2026.2699357>



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Published online: 07 Jul 2026.



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How can we improve gender balance in local government? Family-friendly policies and static ambition in England

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ABSTRACT

Women's representation in European local governments remains stagnant at around one-third of councillors. One explanation for this longstanding gender gap relates to structural barriers blocking the supply of women candidates, including working practices which are not compatible with caring responsibilities. Yet, so far we do not know whether measures governments can implement to remedy this, including reimbursing care expenses and remote working, increase women's political ambition. To answer this question, the study uses a survey experiment fielded to local councillors in England (N = 534). The survey manipulates exposure to a bundled set of family-friendly policies in a hypothetical council to identify the causal effect of such policies on static political ambition (councillors' willingness to run for their current level of office), and explores heterogeneous effects by gender. The introduction of family-friendly policies significantly increases women's, but not men's, willingness to run for office again. Analysis of open-ended survey responses further reveals that women councillors more frequently brought up the difficulty of balancing care and work with a political role, while men were less likely to mention this. Overall, the study contributes new evidence about the important role that family policies might play in closing gender gaps in political ambition.

ARTICLE HISTORY Received 26 November 2025; Accepted 1 July 2026

KEYWORDS Gender and politics; political ambition; local government; family-friendly policies; survey experiment

Women are underrepresented in local government. In the EU, for example, women hold 35 percent of local council seats on average, with slow progress observed over the past fifteen years.¹ This pattern is striking because local

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politics often serves as the first step into office-holding and a critical training ground for future political leaders. Further, local councils are often responsible for decisions that directly affect citizens' everyday life – from child- and elder care to housing and transport – areas where women's perspectives are particularly salient given persistent gendered divisions of labour. Indeed, increased numbers of women in local office are linked to the expansion of these same policies (Bratton & Ray, 2002; Randall & Fisher, 2001). Ensuring women's presence in local decision-making arenas is therefore not only a matter of fairness but also one of democratic responsiveness. Despite this, many democracies struggle to attract and retain women in local office.

Research highlights multiple barriers – cultural, institutional, and practical – that inhibit women's retention, including masculine political cultures, resource constraints, and the incompatibility of political work with caring responsibilities (Bernhard et al., 2021; Bos et al., 2022; Lawless & Fox, 2015; Silberman, 2015; Wylie, 2020). Of particular interest for our study is the growing body of scholarship on *gender-sensitive institutions*. This research argues that political organisations are not neutral spaces; they are structured around gendered assumptions about time, availability, and care (Childs & Palmieri, 2023; Krook & Mackay, 2010). From this perspective, barriers to women's representation are embedded in the male-constructed organisation of political life. However, we still know little about whether institutional reforms that make political workplaces more family-friendly – such as flexible meeting times or child care reimbursements – can actually enhance women's static political ambition and thereby increase retention rates.

We argue that improving gender balance in local government requires not only recruiting more women but also reshaping the institutional conditions under which political work takes place. Building on the gender-sensitive institutions framework, we propose that family-friendly institutional design – policies that make political roles more compatible with caregiving – can increase political ambition, particularly among women. We theorise that these policies operate through a *constraint-reduction mechanism*: by lowering the anticipated logistical and emotional costs of officeholding, they make political participation seem more feasible and sustainable. Because women remain more likely than men to shoulder unpaid care work, we expect them to be more responsive to such policies. Accordingly, we advance two main hypotheses: (1) that exposure to family-friendly institutional arrangements increases political ambition overall, and (2) that this effect is stronger among women.

To investigate these hypotheses, we conducted a survey experiment among 534 sitting local councillors in England, randomly assigning respondents to read a vignette describing a hypothetical local council either with or without family-friendly policies, including dependent-care reimbursement and flexible, remote working. England offers an informative setting: local councillors typically serve in part-time roles with modest remuneration and

often combine their political responsibilities with employment and other responsibilities, including caregiving.² Importantly, such caring constraints extend beyond dependent children to include adult care and eldercare, and demographic research shows that women shoulder a disproportionate share of these responsibilities across the life course (Dukhovnov & Zagheni, 2015; Ice, 2023). Institutional arrangements that reduce work–life conflicts may be especially consequential for retention in office in this context. While we focus on England here, the mechanisms we examine – reducing the practical costs of officeholding and signalling a more care-inclusive institutional environment – are relevant to other political systems where elected officials similarly balance political office with work and family responsibilities.

Our experimental design isolates the causal impact of family-friendly institutional arrangements on councillors' willingness to run for the same level of office again. Following Schlesinger (1966)'s classic framework, we thus focus on static ambition: the decision to remain in one's present level of office, an understudied point in the political pipeline that is especially relevant for understanding gendered patterns of retention. Consistent with expectations, exposure to the family-friendly council significantly increases static ambition: on a 0–10 scale, mean ambition rose from 7.3 in the control condition to 7.8 in the treatment condition ($p < 0.05$), a modest but meaningful increase of about one-quarter of a standard deviation even in a population already highly politically engaged. Gender-disaggregated analyses reveal that among women councillors, exposure to family-friendly policies raised ambition by nearly a full point (+0.94, $p = 0.004$), while there was no discernible effect among men, effectively eliminating the baseline gender gap in ambition. These results provide clear support for both hypotheses: family-friendly institutional designs boost political ambition overall (H1) and do so disproportionately among women (H2).

Our findings have important implications for understanding gender gaps in political ambition and representation. Although scholars and policymakers have long argued that improving work–life balance through institutional reforms could lower barriers to women's political participation, there has been little empirical evidence testing whether family-friendly policies actually influence ambition. Our study addresses this gap by providing experimental evidence from sitting councillors. We provide rare causal evidence that a bundle of feasible, relatively inexpensive, workplace policies – remote meeting options and care reimbursements – can meaningfully increase women's willingness to (continue to) participate in politics. This suggests that the day-to-day policies and practice of local governance can either perpetuate or mitigate gender gaps in representation. At the same time, our open-ended data reveal that the mere existence of family-friendly policies is not sufficient: councillors often reported that dependent-care reimbursements were poorly communicated, inconsistently applied, or embedded in

cultures that discouraged their use. These findings highlight that institutional design and culture must align for reforms to be effective, in line with research on gender-sensitive institutions.

Gender, static ambition, and retention in local office

Despite decades of attention to gender equality in representation, women remain under-represented in local politics. As of 2024, women make up just 37% of UK local councillors (Oscar Research 2024), a modest increase from 28% in 1997 and 33% in 2017 (Local Government Commission 2017). The statistics are representative of tendencies seen across Europe— 34.5% of all local councillors in the EU are women, with the EEA average rising to 40% (European Institute for Gender Equality 2025). Thus, progress has been slow and uneven. This gender inequality is significant for several reasons. While the descriptive representation of women in key democratic institutions is a reflection of a society's gender equality progress, there is also evidence that women local politicians' differentiated political socialisation process lead to them valuing, promoting and producing different policies than male peers, thus also affecting substantive representation (Holman, 2015). Moreover, local politics is a pipeline to higher offices (Budd et al., 2016; Crowder-Meyer & Lauderdale, 2014), meaning that gendered dynamics at the local level may hinder equal access to the political career pipeline (Holman, 2017).

Women are consistently underrepresented throughout the political pipeline. Although women candidates are elected at roughly the same rates as men (Teele et al., 2018), they are disadvantaged at steps before and after reaching political office. For instance, women's interest in politics decreases with their heavier care burdens (Ferrín Pereira et al. 2025; Naurin et al., 2023; Quaranta & Sani, 2018; Weeks, 2026), they engage less with various forms of political participation (Coffé & Bolzendahl, 2010), join political parties and are selected as a candidate less frequently than men (Crowder-Meyer, 2013; Fox & Lawless, 2010), and finally remain in office for fewer terms than their male counterparts. In this paper, we focus on this final step of the political pipeline.

While much of the literature focuses on women reaching political office, disparities do not disappear once women enter political institutions. In the UK, for example, women are significantly more likely than men to leave office after only one or two terms (Allen, 2012), and a gender gap in the length of council tenure has been observed consistently over time (Borisjuk et al., 2007). Women in U.S. state legislatures, similarly, exhibit higher turnover rates than their male counterparts (Butcher & Haynes, 2024). Studies find that women are most underrepresented in senior, prestigious roles (Muriaas & Stavenes, 2024; Smith et al., 2012). A significant part of progressing

gender representation in politics, then, relies on improving retention rates among women politicians.

Our research contributes to this by examining a prerequisite of women's retention, namely gender differences in static ambition. The literature identifies several types of political ambition, from *nascent* ambition (taking an interest in running for office in the first place; Lawless & Fox, 2005) to – for office-holders – *discrete* ambition (desire to serve only temporarily before exiting politics), *static* ambition (desire to remain in current office) and *progressive* ambition (aspiring to higher office) (Schlesinger, 1966). By focusing on static ambition, we contribute to the literature on the retention of women in politics, leaving ongoing questions about nascent and progressive ambition to future research.

Although most research concentrates on progressive ambition, there is a growing literature on static ambition and on women's retention in office. Findings show that institutional design and party organisation matters. The former include incompatible working practices, discrimination and sexism from colleagues, and lack of access to networks, mentors, and information (Allen, 2012; Bazeley et al., 2017; British Council 2018; Hills, 1983; Rao, 2005). Specific research on retention and advancement in local politics also shows that it is related to a range of institutional factors. For instance, a gender gap in progressive ambition is linked to lower institutional satisfaction and concerns about the compatibility of political work with family life (Butcher & Haynes, 2024; Moore & Hibbing, 1998).

Family responsibilities, and having young children especially, is a recurring theme in the literature on women's retention in politics. Research indicates that being a parent is a heavier burden in political work for women than men, in that mothers but not fathers have lower average legislative output and are less successful in reaching leadership positions (Frech et al., 2024). Women politicians also find the work-family conflict more challenging than male colleagues (Franceschet & Rayment, 2026). Having children has also been directly linked to retention in Germany, where parenthood reduces the likelihood of serving multiple terms especially among women (Franceschet et al. 2025). Even in gender-egalitarian Sweden and Norway, higher levels of work-family conflict are reported among young women politicians (Johansson Sevä & Öun, 2019) and women are more likely than men to drop out of local politics after having their first child (Fiva & King, 2024).

Indeed, parents are severely underrepresented in the UK parliament and beyond, warranting a closer look at what kind of institutional designs could potentially accommodate caring responsibilities (Campbell & Childs, 2014; Frech, 2025). Women face strong social expectations to shoulder the majority of care and household management, shaping both their time availability and their self-perceived suitability for political roles. For example, the 'intensive mothering' paradigm dominant across many Western democracies (and

particularly among the highly educated) holds that mothers bear primary responsibility for childrearing, while fathers are seen as secondary helpers (Damaske, 2013; Hays, 1996). These gendered expectations are reflected in women's disproportionate time spent in physical household labour (Lachance-Grzela & Bouchard, 2010; Sullivan, 2018), and in their enduring responsibility for the bulk of the domestic 'mental load', the cognitive work required to keep family life running smoothly (Weeks & Ruppanner, 2025).

We examine whether institutional contexts can alleviate the pressures of this gendered division of labour by testing the impact of family-friendly policies on static ambition among English local councillors. Evidence from labour market studies shows that national-level family supports significantly increase women's employment and reduce gender gaps in economic participation (Ferragina, 2020), while family-friendly workplace policies improve productivity at the firm level (Ribeiro et al., 2023; Susanto et al., 2022). By analogy, institutional supports within legislatures may similarly help equalise participation and retention in local government. Better accommodating for care within political institutions is therefore a highly promising avenue for improving gender balance in representation. Such measures not only address a persistent structural constraint on women's political engagement but may increasingly benefit men with caring responsibilities as gender norms evolve.

Gender-sensitive institutions and family-friendly policy support

The literature on gender-sensitive parliaments systematically considers the potential of family-friendly policies in political institutions. This line of research argues that parliaments are gendered organisations in that they contain institutional practices and norms working against gender equality, like other workplaces (Acker, 1990; Crawford & Pini, 2011). According to Palmieri (2018), four dimensions define a gender-sensitive parliament: (1) all members, female and male, and parties accept responsibility in promoting gender equality both in policy and as a process, (2) legal frameworks to promote gender equality inside the parliament, (3) an institutionalisation of gender mainstreaming, and (4) active promotion of a workplace culture that eliminates discrimination and prejudicial norms and attitudes toward women members and staff.

Our research is situated primarily within the second dimension, legal frameworks that accommodate care responsibilities: namely, family-friendly policies. However, we recognise that the effectiveness of such measures depends on organisational culture (the fourth dimension), since a supportive environment is essential to ensure that policies can be used without stigma. Indeed, progress on any dimension of gender sensitivity is highly contingent

on institutional culture (Childs & Palmieri, 2023). Therefore, we include reference to a culture of inclusion as a feature of our experiment.

Becoming a gender-sensitive parliament, and therefore also a gender-sensitive local government, requires substantial reform in workplace practices dealing with work hours and other aspects of work-life balance (Ahrens & Palmieri, 2024). While research has underlined the importance of childcare provision and opportunities to take parental leave in order to promote gender equal workplaces (Erikson & Josefsson, 2022), this aspect of gendered organisations has mostly been mapped descriptively—i.e., is it offered at a given political institution or not (Crawford and Pini 2011; Wängnerud, 2015; but see Allen et al. 2016 for an exception). Research further investigates public opinion on family-friendly practices in parliaments, finding strong support for politicians (especially women) who take parental leave (Smith, 2025).

While scholars and policymakers have long speculated that structural supports for work-life balance could lower barriers for women (e.g., Linsley et al. 2006; McNeil et al., 2017; Fawcett Society 2023), studies have yet to examine the relationship between family-friendly policies and political ambition empirically. To address this gap, we field a survey experiment with English local councillors to test whether institutional reforms designed to promote work-life balance can increase women's static political ambition. Specifically, we test whether councillors express greater willingness to stand for election to a hypothetical council that offers both (a) reimbursement for child or dependent care costs and (b) virtual meeting options, where legally permitted. These policies represent low-cost, scalable interventions targeting well-documented women's barriers to participation and retention, thereby making the council more gender-sensitive.

Both policies were part of a set of reforms proposed by the UK Local Government Association (LGA, 2019) to help councils attract and retain more diverse representatives. Not only does this ground our experimental treatment in a real current debate, increasing experimental realism for our participants (Mutz, 2011), the policies proposed by the LGA are specifically designed to mitigate well-documented logistical and financial barriers that disproportionately affect women's political participation and progression. They may also be more politically feasible than alternatives like gender quotas, which are implemented consistently only by the Labour Party in the UK (Oscar Research 2024) and face limited public support (Coffé et al., 2025).

We expect that the effects of these family-friendly policies will be stronger among women. Although family-friendly policies have the potential to improve the static ambition of any politician with caregiving responsibilities, due to the gendered distribution of this labour women will on average benefit more from being provided relief. This is further supported by the empirical findings on the general labour market that family-friendly policies first and foremost improve women's labour market participation. For

example, research finds that the availability of flexible working helps mothers stay in employment, and decreases the likelihood that they significantly reduce working hours (Chung & Van der Horst, 2018). Similarly, investment in public child care significantly improves maternal employment (e.g., Boeckmann et al., 2015). While such policies may benefit both women and men, effects are generally larger for women because mothers are substantially more likely than fathers to adjust employment in response to care demands (Kleven et al., 2025). The theoretical mechanism at hand is therefore gendered constraint alleviation.

Another mechanism is theoretically possible: that implementing family-friendly policies prompts a general attitudinal shift, resulting in a horizontal effect of our experimental treatment. While research on attitudes towards family-friendly policies does show a positive feedback effect on general support (Chung & Meuleman, 2017; Franceschet & Rayment, 2026; Tavits et al., 2024), the strongest predictors of support remain within individual self-interest where women are consistently more supportive than men (Helgøy & Van Hootegeem, 2026; Mischke, 2014). Moreover, even if men's support of these policies would increase with exposure, this would not necessarily manifest as change in their own static ambition. We therefore argue that a constraint alleviation mechanism is more likely here, while acknowledging that a more general attitudinal shift is a possibility longer-term.

Based on the preceding discussion, we derive the following hypotheses to test the impact of family-friendly council policies on static political ambition:

H1 (Main Treatment Effect): Exposure to a council that offers family-friendly policies will increase political ambition among councillors compared to a council offering no such policies.

H2 (Gender Interaction Effect): The positive effect of these family-friendly policies on political ambition will be greater among women than among men.

As we limit ourselves to two family-friendly policies in our experimental treatment, introduced on the premise that there is a culture for actual uptake of these policies, we test the effect of general family friendliness on councillors' static ambition. However, it is also valuable to understand which specific policies local councillors actually prefer. Therefore, we also explore councillors' policy preferences. Here, we are interested in preference patterns between different family-friendly policies (childcare support, remote working and parental leave), but also how preferences for family-friendly policies measure up against other gender-sensitive workplace policies (mentoring programmes and codes of conduct).

Data & methods

Sample and data collection

To test our hypotheses, we rely on original experimental data collected in August and September of 2024 ($N = 534$). The sample consists of local councillors in England, who were invited to participate via email. There are approximately 17,000 elected local councillors in England, serving across 317 local authorities (LGIU, [n.d.](#)). To collect a sample with broad coverage across council types, we systematically gathered councillor contact information from publicly available email directories on local authority websites. This resulted in a database of 7,516 councillors drawn from a diverse sample of English local councils, including 16 of 21 county councils, 59 of 164 district councils, 49 of 63 unitary councils, 13 of 36 metropolitan districts, and 10 of 33 London boroughs.³ Invitations to participate in the survey were emailed directly to councillors using this database. A total of 534 participants completed the survey, yielding a response rate just over 7%.⁴

Table 1 presents summary statistics of our sample. Women make up 53% of the sample, slightly overrepresenting their share in the national population of local authority councillors in England, where women constitute approximately 41% (Buchanan, [2025](#)). The plurality of respondents are aged 50–64 (39%), followed closely by those aged 65 and over (38%). This reflects national patterns (Local Government Association [2022](#)). The sample is overwhelmingly white (93%), again closely matching national figures (92%). Regarding employment status, 55% report being in employment (including full-time, part-time, and self-employed), comparable to the national average of 48% and consistent with the high share of retired councillors. Around 20% report having children under 18 at home, which is expected due to the

Table 1. Summary statistics.

Statistic	N	Mean	St. Dev.	Min	Max
Woman	530	0.532	0.499	0	1
Age < 40	534	0.107	0.309	0	1
Age 40–49	534	0.131	0.338	0	1
Age 50–64	534	0.386	0.487	0	1
Age 65 +	534	0.376	0.485	0	1
Employed	534	0.549	0.498	0	1
White	534	0.925	0.263	0	1
Kids < 18 at home	534	0.199	0.399	0	1
Council experience < 4 yrs	534	0.375	0.484	0	1
Council experience 4–8 yrs	534	0.178	0.383	0	1
Council experience 8–12 yrs	534	0.129	0.336	0	1
Council experience 12 + yrs	534	0.318	0.466	0	1
Labour	534	0.406	0.492	0	1
Conservative	534	0.223	0.417	0	1
Liberal Democrat	534	0.199	0.399	0	1
Green	534	0.103	0.304	0	1

age distribution of the sample. The sample includes councillors with a range of experience in office: 38% have served fewer than four years, while 32% have over twelve years of experience.

In terms of party affiliation, 41% of the sample are Labour councillors, 22% Conservative, 20% Liberal Democrat, and 10% Green. Compared to national party composition following the 2024 local elections, Labour is slightly over-represented (national share: 35%), as are Liberal Democrats (national share: 17%) and Greens (national share: 5%). Conservative councillors, by contrast, are underrepresented relative to their national share of 28%. Overall, the sample is broadly representative of the demographic profile of English local councillors, but overrepresents women and underrepresents Conservative councillors.

Case selection

Our study takes place in England, which is part of the UK's liberal welfare state with minimal family support provided by the government (Ciccia & Verloo, 2012). This means that the family-friendly policies we test in our experiment are not offered on a general basis by the government, which would be the case in some other European countries like the Nordics (Ellingsæter, 2024). In other words, workplace policies potentially play a larger role for individuals in our country setting given the absence of support otherwise, making our treatment highly relevant. Our more specific case of English local councils also makes for a suitable test of our hypotheses. Most local councillors combine their councillor role with a 'regular' job, unless they are retired. This likely means that they take on more public engagement (paid work and politics) than average, which could logically increase their work-life conflict and thus their demand for family-friendly policies.

Experimental design and measures

To test our main hypothesis—that the presence of family-friendly policies increases political ambition among sitting councillors—we employed an experimental vignette methodology. Participants were randomly assigned to one of two conditions: a control group that read a baseline description of a hypothetical council, or a treatment group that read an identical description with the addition of two family-friendly policies. This design allows us to isolate the effect of this package of family-friendly policy interventions on respondents' self-reported willingness to run for office.

The council described in the vignette—Ravensford Borough Council—is fictional but realistic, modelled closely on the institutional features of a typical English unitary authority. Both versions of the vignette stated that the council serves 180,000 residents, has 60 councillors across 20 wards,

and operates under a leader and cabinet governance structure. Councillors without executive roles were described as spending 15 h per week on council duties and receiving a basic annual allowance of £7,000—figures consistent with national averages (LGA n.d.; LGiU n.d.). All of these features serve to enhance construct validity.

In the treatment condition, participants were additionally informed that the council *'has a clear policy and culture encouraging councillors to claim childcare costs and adult dependent care costs, enabling councillors to meet their caring responsibilities. It also uses technology (telephone and video conferencing) whenever possible to enable flexible and efficient remote working and participation in meetings'*. These two policies reflect concrete, actionable recommendations from the Local Government Association's (LGA) family-friendly council toolkit, and were previously identified as potential determinants of increased political participation among women (LGA 2019).

Because both policies were presented together in a single treatment, the experiment does not allow us to separate the effects of remote working from those of care reimbursement. Moreover, the effect of the treatment may function not only through practical support but also by signalling a more gender-sensitive or inclusive institutional culture toward caregiving. We therefore interpret the treatment effect as capturing the impact of a wider family-friendly environment, including the policies of care reimbursement and remote working and a culture to support this. This means that we lose some granularity in our ability to determine which specific component drives the observed effect on static ambition – a point we return to in our analysis using descriptive and open-ended response data, described below. Conceptually, the bundled treatment emphasises family-friendly institutional context (policies and culture) rather than other mechanisms such as mentoring or role-modelling. The full experimental vignettes are shown in Appendix B. Balance tests (see Appendix B) indicate no significant differences in key characteristics between the treatment and control groups.

After reading the vignette, participants were asked to indicate how likely they would be to stand for election to that council (our measure of static political ambition), using a 0–10 scale, where 0 represented 'would not stand for election' and 10 'would definitely stand for election'. This outcome, our key dependent variable, mirrors measures used in large-scale attitudinal surveys. We follow conventional benchmarks for interpreting standardised mean differences: changes of 0.2, 0.5, and 0.8 standard deviations correspond to small, medium, and large effects, respectively (Cohen, 2013).

To gain further insight into policy preferences, all respondents were then asked which council policies would positively influence their decision to run. They could select all applicable options from a list of five policies: childcare support, remote working, parental leave, code of conduct (concerning sexual harassment and anti-discrimination) and training and mentoring (or

none of the above). These follow-up items shed light on which specific forms of institutional support respondents view as most consequential, complementing the bundled family-friendly experimental treatment. Following this, an optional open-ended question invited councillors to explain why the selected policies would affect their decision. Finally, demographic information was collected at the end of the survey.

Analytical approach

Our empirical analysis proceeds in three stages. First, we test our main hypotheses, concerning the overall treatment effect and its gendered impact, using differences in means and OLS regression to estimate the effect of exposure to family-friendly policies on councillors' static ambition. Second, we analyze councillors' stated policy preferences to assess which institutional supports are most preferred, and whether these preferences are themselves shaped by treatment exposure. These policy preference and additional subgroup analyses (by party and parenthood status) are exploratory and intended to identify suggestive patterns, rather than test hypotheses. Third, we turn to qualitative evidence from open-ended survey responses to explore how councillors explain their preferences in their own words, offering further insight into the mechanisms underlying our findings.

Experimental results: exposure to family-friendly council policies increases political ambition

Figure 1 presents the average treatment effect, operationalised as the difference in mean political ambition between the treated and control groups. The same results are presented using ordinary least squares (OLS) regression in Table C.2 of the Appendix. In the control condition, where the council has no family-friendly policies, the mean level of political ambition is 7.3 on a 0–10 scale. In the treatment condition—where the council is described as offering dependent care reimbursements and flexible remote working options—the mean increases to 7.8. This represents an average increase of approximately 0.5 units. A Welch Two Sample t-test confirms that this difference is statistically significant at conventional levels ($p < 0.05$).

While the absolute size of the effect may appear modest, it is meaningful relative to the overall distribution: it corresponds to an increase of 0.51 units on the 0–10 scale ($\approx 5\%$ of the full range) and approximately 0.2 standard deviations. This represents a small effect for a brief framing treatment. These findings offer support for Hypothesis 1.

To test Hypothesis 2, Figure 2 disaggregates the average treatment effects by gender. Among women councillors, the mean level of political ambition in the control group is 6.72, compared to 7.66 in the treatment group—a

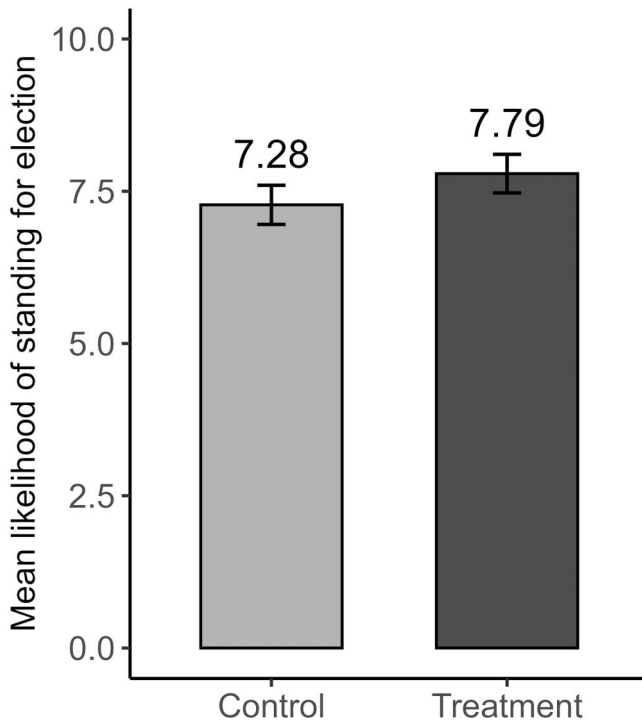


Figure 1. Observed Means by Treatment Group with 95% Cis. Note: The survey question reads, 'Below is a description of a local council. Please indicate how likely you would be to stand for election to this council on a scale of 0–10, where 0 corresponds to would not stand for election and 10 corresponds to would definitely stand for election'. Data include 534 respondents.

statistically significant increase of 0.94 points ($p = 0.004$). This effect represents a more substantial shift, amounting to approximately 0.35 standard deviations. By contrast, the treatment has no discernible effect among men in our sample: ambition levels are nearly identical in the control (mean = 7.94) and treatment (mean = 7.90) groups ($p = 0.90$).⁵ Interaction results reported in Table C.2 of the Appendix confirm that the gender difference in treatment effect is statistically significant. These results are consistent with Hypothesis 2: when presented with a council setting that accommodates caring responsibilities and enables flexible participation, women report significantly higher levels of static ambition, while men show no detectable change.⁶

A second notable finding is that the treatment condition appears to eliminate the gender gap in political ambition. In the control group, men report substantially higher ambition than women (mean = 7.9 vs. 6.7), a difference of 1.2 points on the 0–10 scale that is statistically significant at $p < 0.001$. By

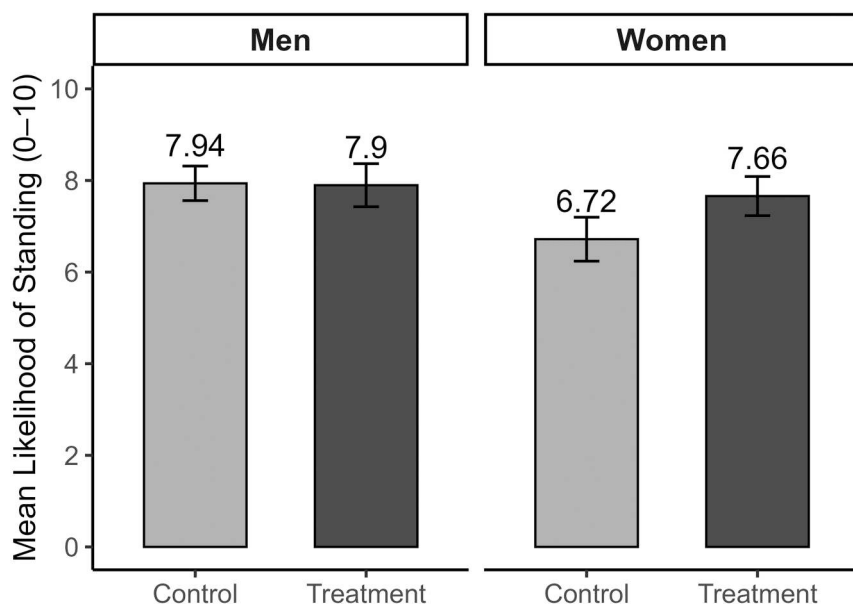
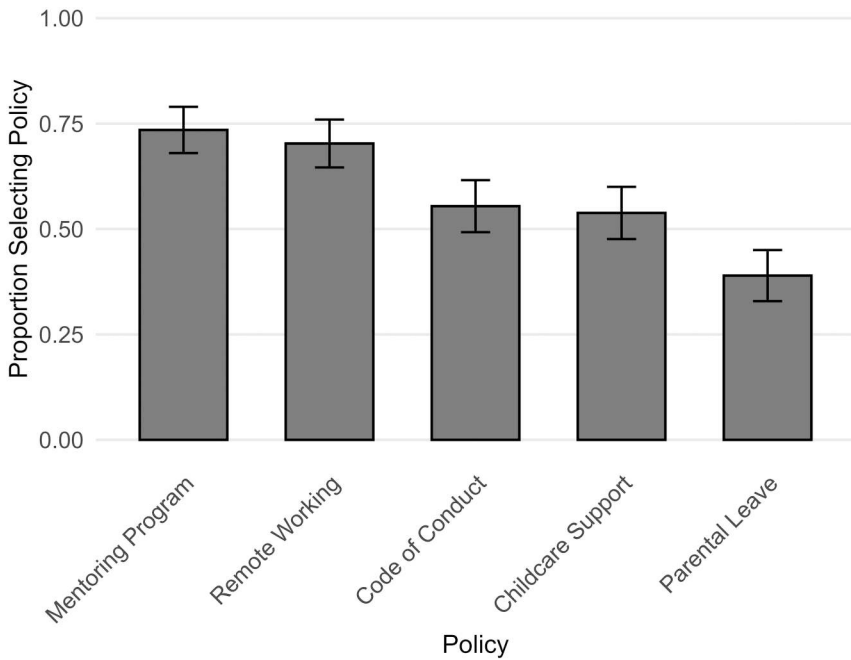


Figure 2. Observed Means by Treatment Group and Gender with 95% Cis. *Note:* The survey question reads, ‘Below is a description of a local council. Please indicate how likely you would be to stand for election to this council on a scale of 0–10, where 0 corresponds to would not stand for election and 10 corresponds to would definitely stand for election’. Data include 530 respondents.

contrast, in the treatment group, this gender gap disappears: men and women report nearly identical levels of ambition (means = 7.9 and 7.7, respectively), and the difference is not statistically significant ($p = 0.47$). These results suggest that the family-friendly policy exposure does not simply boost women’s ambition in absolute terms, but could also play an important equalising role — bringing women’s average levels of ambition in line with those of men.

Councillors’ policy preferences

Having examined the impact of the treatment on political ambition, we now turn to councillors’ policy preferences. Because this analysis examines several policies and is not tied to specific hypotheses, we treat these results as exploratory rather than confirmatory. After answering the question about political ambition, respondents were asked which council policies would positively influence their decision to run, with the option to select all that apply from five policies: child- and adult-care support, remote working, parental leave, code of conduct, and training and mentoring (or none of the above). To establish a baseline understanding of what types of institutional



Bars show proportion of control group respondents selecting each policy (with 95% CIs).

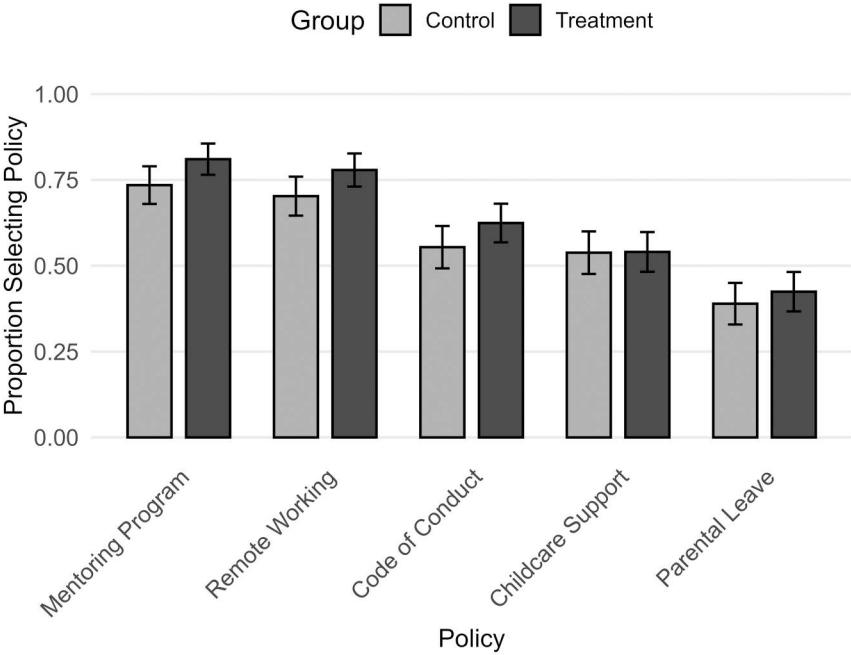
Figure 3. Policy Preferences Among Control Group Respondents. Note: The survey question reads, ‘Which of the following policies that a council could implement would positively influence your decision to run for election to a local council? (Check all that apply):’ Data include 249 respondents (control group only).

support councillors want, we first examine responses from the control group. [Figure 3](#) displays the proportion of control group respondents selecting each policy. The most commonly selected policies were mentoring programmes (73.5%) and remote working (70.3%), followed by the code of conduct (55.4%) and care support (53.8%). Parental leave was less frequently selected (39.0%), which could be explained by the majority of councillors not having dependent children at home and parental leave being a facilitation of absence, as opposed to care support which facilitates presence. Still, the relatively low support for care cost reimbursement (one of the policies we expect to influence static ambition) presents a puzzle which we address more fully in the qualitative analysis, below.

We also examined whether preferences for these policies differ by gender (see Appendix Table C.3). Across all five policy areas, women expressed higher average levels of support than men. In some cases, these gender differences are substantial—for example, support for codes of conduct (concerning sexual harassment and anti-discrimination) was nearly 8 percentage points higher among women, and support for parental leave was over 4

percentage points higher. However, none of these differences are statistically significant at conventional levels, which may reflect limited statistical power in the smaller control-only sample. Overall, these patterns suggest that while support for institutional reforms is broadly shared across genders, certain policies—particularly those addressing gendered discrimination and caregiving responsibilities—resonate more strongly with women.

Next, we consider whether exposure to the treatment influences which policies councillors say would positively affect their decision to run (Figure 4; see also Table C.4 in Appendix). This helps us understand how the family-friendly policy vignette primes or makes more salient certain policies in particular that could inform levels of ambition. Consistent with the treatment’s emphasis on flexibility and support, we find increases in support for both remote working (from 70.3% to 77.9%; Welch two-sample t-test significant at $p = 0.046$) and mentoring programmes (from 73.5% to 81.1%; $p = 0.038$) among those exposed to the treatment. We also observe increased support for a clear code of conduct (from 55.4% in control to 62.5% treated; $p < 0.1$), suggesting that the treatment may also heighten awareness



Bars show proportion selecting each policy by treatment group (with 95% CIs).

Figure 4. Observed Support for Council Policies by Treatment. Note: The survey question reads, ‘Which of the following policies that a council could implement would positively influence your decision to run for election to a local council? (Check all that apply):’ Data include 534 respondents.

of institutional norms and expectations around gendered discrimination. By contrast, [Figure 3](#) shows that support for childcare policy (ability to claim costs for care) remains unchanged across groups, despite being explicitly mentioned in the treatment. Parental leave policies show a small increase in the treatment group, but this is not significant.⁷

While all five policies are relevant to reducing structural barriers, the family-friendly council vignette (which mentioned both remote working and child care reimbursement) primarily increases support for remote working and mentoring. One possible explanation is that low-cost, broadly applicable supports like remote working and mentoring are seen as more immediately actionable or universally beneficial, whereas care reimbursement and parental leave may be seen as more niche, expensive, or simply less relevant for the current pool of (on average, older) local councillors. We return to this point in the next section, where open-ended responses help explain the null finding and relatively low support for care reimbursement in particular.

Councillors' explanations of how policies influence their decisions to run in their own words

To gain further insight into policy preferences, we analyzed the open-ended responses in which councillors explained why the policies they selected might influence their decision to run. We applied keyness statistics—a method that identifies words significantly more frequent in one group's responses compared to another—to explore thematic differences by gender. Of the respondents, 230 women (81.6%) and 180 men (72.6%) provided comments. [Figure 5](#) displays the top 20 words most strongly associated with women's responses relative to men's, based on chi-squared values.

As with any keyword analysis, individual terms should not be over-interpreted in isolation. However, the overall pattern reveals relevant gendered differences. Women's responses are distinguished by terms such as 'responsibilities', 'caring', 'carers', and 'evening'. These words suggest that women councillors in particular emphasise balancing care responsibilities and the temporal demands that influence their political engagement. This is especially interesting given the relatively low share of councillors with dependent children at home. As discussed in the following paragraphs, individual responses suggest it is nonetheless a more salient concern for women, and that women's caring responsibilities are not limited to one life stage.

Men's explanations include words related more to formal roles and procedural aspects such as 'place', 'candidates', and 'elected', indicating a focus on institutional and electoral processes rather than caregiving or flexibility concerns. Overall, the keyness analysis suggests that women councillors frame their preferences within a broader understanding of institutional

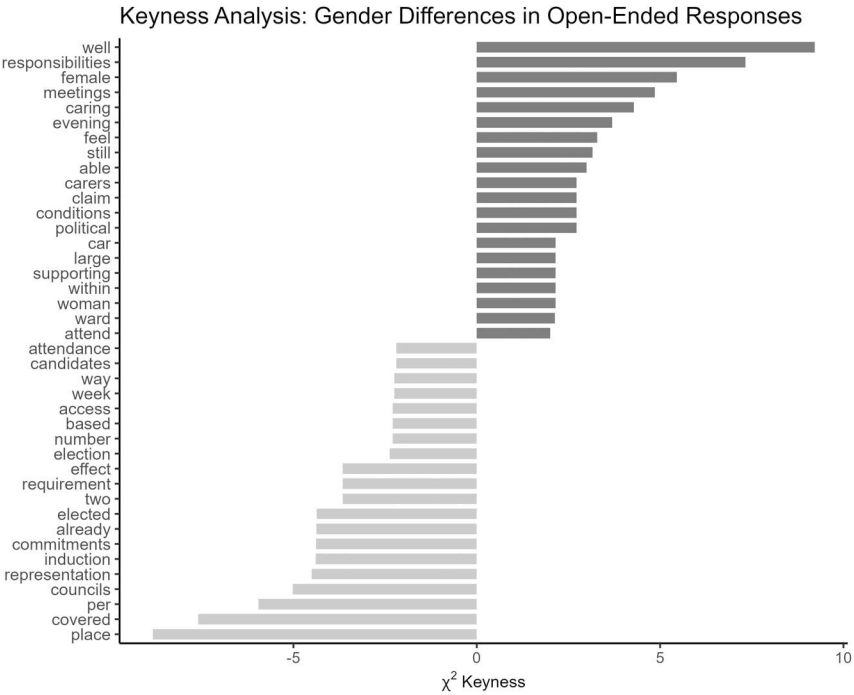


Figure 5. Keyness Statistics: Comparing Men and Women’s Explanations for Policy Prioritisation. Note: The survey question reads, ‘Could you explain why the policies you have ticked would influence your decision?’ Data include 410 respondents.

support, one that includes the need to juggle both caregiving roles and political responsibilities.

Qualitative analysis of these comments helps explain why care reimbursement did not emerge as a more prominent policy priority despite being explicitly mentioned in the treatment. Many women councillors described care policies as inadequate or difficult to access in practice. For instance, one Labour councillor (woman, 40–49) noted that unclear guidance and a culture discouraging claims mean that many do not use available childcare reimbursements. She said, ‘Most councils don’t explain how expenses work and the experience I have is that most councillors don’t claim as there is a perception that they get allowances so shouldn’t claim expenses’. Similarly, a Liberal Democrat councillor (woman, 50–64) emphasised the challenges posed by irregular meeting times, ‘which makes securing reliable and safe care for dependents extremely difficult’, while a Green councillor (woman, 40–49) described childcare policies as ‘nigh on useless’, given restrictions on eligible providers and inconvenient meeting schedules.

Several respondents also pointed to cultural and reputational barriers – as one respondent put it, ‘There is still a negative culture around claiming costs

for childcare'. A Liberal Democrat woman (50–64) explained that although her council permits childcare claims, she chooses not to claim due to concerns about fairness and public scrutiny over expenses. These sentiments reflect a lack of trust and practical obstacles that may reduce support for childcare policies, contrasting with stronger enthusiasm for more flexible supports like remote working and mentoring.

Speaking directly to these cultural barriers, some Conservative men explicitly opposed extending childcare cost coverage, framing it as an unnecessary taxpayer burden or a personal responsibility. One Conservative man (65+) argued that, 'Adding childcare and dependent care costs would simply add to the taxpayers' burden. If you can't do the job, don't get elected', while a younger Conservative man (18–24) dismissed the idea because, 'Childcare costs aren't covered by other employers.' Conversely, Conservative women often highlighted the importance of support for carers and valued initiatives such as reimbursement for caring costs and remote meeting options. For example, a Conservative woman (65+) stressed that, 'help with care costs can make a huge financial difference', while another (50–64) noted the benefits of virtual meetings because, 'I have caring responsibility so I can be at home keeping an eye on loved ones'.

These practical and cultural barriers contribute to a lack of trust in care reimbursement policies. Consequently, councillors perceive other policies like remote working and mentoring as more immediately beneficial and actionable. This explains the treatment's stronger positive effect on preferences for remote working and mentoring programmes relative to care support. While family-friendly policies are broadly valued, the political context significantly influences perceived relevance and effectiveness—particularly for care support, which remains contested and seemingly under-utilised in many councils. Thus, while we cannot distinguish which of the family-friendly policies included in our treatment drives the experimental effect on static ambition, these responses lead us to suspect that remote working is doing more of the work.

Conclusion

How do family-friendly policies influence local politicians' political ambition? In this study, we offer novel causal evidence on whether legislative policies – namely, reimbursing child and adult dependent care costs and allowing remote participation – increase politicians' willingness to stand for election again. We argue that gender imbalance in local government, and indeed at all levels of office, is tied to women's disproportionate time and mental energy spent in household and care work. The literature on gender-sensitive institutions offers clear ways to help accommodate family responsibilities through legal frameworks, and family-friendly policies are also actively being debated within local governments.

In line with expectations, we find that exposure to this set of family-friendly policies significantly increases English local councillors' willingness to stand for election in a hypothetical council, moving the average ambition score from 7.3–7.8. This shift is entirely driven by women councillors, whose ambition increases from 6.7 in the control condition to 7.7 when exposed to a council offering family-friendly policies. While women report lower ambition in the control condition, we find no gender gap in ambition when the hypothetical council offers flexible remote participation and reimbursement for care costs. At the same time, our descriptive results show that some policies, namely mentoring and remote participation, are more immediately attractive to councillors than care reimbursement schemes. Our qualitative analysis suggests that this is because existing reimbursement policies are often perceived as stigmatised or difficult to use in practice, which limits their appeal even where they formally exist. A key implication of our findings is therefore that family-friendly policies can help close gender gaps in static political ambition, but their effectiveness depends on a culture that supports their use.

Our findings contribute to the literature on gender and static political ambition by offering causal evidence for one potential pathway toward the improved retention of women in local office. By highlighting the relevance of the gendered division of household and care work, our findings align with research showing that working practices that are incompatible with women's typical needs harm gender balance in political institutions (Allen, 2012). Previous research has also shown that women's propensity to run for office is the highest at the local level of politics (Coffé et al., 2023), likely because it is closest to home. Our results underline that locality in itself is not sufficient—family-friendly work practices have the potential to promote gender balance further.

Our findings also contribute to the literature on gender-sensitive political institutions by providing causal evidence that family-friendly institutional reforms can increase women's static political ambition. Existing research has largely mapped whether such policies exist in legislatures; we instead test whether they shape politicians' willingness to seek office. Our results support the theorized importance of a key dimension of gender-sensitive institutions – legal frameworks that accommodate gendered life events (Palmeri, 2018) – by showing that institutional arrangements that make political work compatible with caring responsibilities can help promote a more gender-inclusive political workplace.

Our experiment isolates the causal effect of offering two family-friendly policies within a fictional culture that encourages their take-up. A key limitation of this design is that these elements were necessarily bundled for the sake of this study: remote participation, childcare and dependent-care reimbursement, and a supportive institutional culture were presented together. As a result, we cannot disentangle whether the observed effects are driven primarily by practical supports, by the cultural signal of inclusivity, or by

their interaction. This highlights a fruitful avenue for future research, which could also be extended beyond politicians to those with nascent ambition: examining the relative impact of individual policies, including family-friendly measures, as well as policies that address other mechanisms for women's lower retention such as mentoring programmes or interventions addressing online harassment. Nevertheless, our design provides a test of a realistic policy package that councils could implement jointly.

A second limitation is that our survey experimental approach simplifies complex institutional and cultural dynamics into a controlled setting, leading to some loss of nuance and context. While the external validity of survey experiments does not require full experimental realism as long as the treatment successfully manipulates the independent variable as intended (Mutz, 2011), future research could usefully complement this design with observational studies of local governments that adopt family-friendly policies in practice. Such research could assess not only whether these measures increase women's willingness to stand for election, but also whether they actually improve women's retention, advancement into leadership roles or higher office, and institutional culture over time.

Last, a third limitation is that our analysis relies on a sample of English local councillors which overrepresents women and underrepresents Conservative councillors. While a non-representative sample of councillors does not influence the internal validity of our experiment, the results might nonetheless be biased if we anticipate different treatment effects across certain demographic or political characteristics. Future research could replicate the study in other political and institutional contexts and over-sample certain demographics (e.g., parents of dependent children) to assess the robustness of our findings, especially in systems where care responsibilities and institutional culture and policies differ.

Our results have clear implications for policy and institutional design. Normalising child and adult dependent care reimbursement and flexible, remote participation options across councils would make political office both more accessible – potentially increasing candidate diversity – and more socially acceptable. People often underestimate public support for family-friendly measures (Davidson et al., 2021), yet politicians who make use of them are not penalised (Smith, 2025). Expanding and normalizing these supports could therefore reduce both logistical and normative barriers to women's sustained political participation.

These reforms are particularly timely in the context of ongoing Local Government Reorganisation, which replaces two-tier systems with single-tier unitary authorities. Some councillors have expressed concern that this restructuring risks reducing women's representation by concentrating workloads and limiting opportunities to stand for election.⁸ Given this, now is a perfect time to implement family-friendly policies alongside structural

reform. Policymakers should seize this opportunity not only to ensure that institutional change does not exacerbate existing inequalities, but also to proactively make institutions more gender-inclusive. Overall, our findings suggest that practical, family-friendly policy shifts, supported by an inclusive council culture, can make politics more accessible to women and help local government better reflect the communities it serves.

Notes

1. Data from EIGE as of October 2025 ('MUNICIP' indicator): https://eige.europa.eu/gender-statistics/dgs/indicator/wmidm_pol_parl__wmid_locpol/metadata.
2. Remuneration varies by council, with allowances ranging from £5,245 in Rutland to £18,876 in Birmingham – another factor that might contribute to gender inequalities.
3. The full list of councils sampled is included in Online Appendix A.
4. The survey was approved by our university's relevant ethics boards. We acknowledge that our hypotheses, experimental design, and analysis plans were not preregistered. However, we affirm that we have thoroughly disclosed all experimental conditions and their results. Data and replication files are posted on Harvard Dataverse: <https://doi.org/10.7910/DVN/X27QU6>.
5. Given the relatively small sample size, results should be interpreted as an absence of detectable effects within the limits of the current sample.
6. We also examined heterogeneity in treatment effects by political party and presence of dependent children at home (see Appendix Table C.2). Specifically, we tested whether the treatment effect on political ambition differs between leftist councillors (Green and Labour), parents of dependent children, and other councillors. In both interaction models, the interaction terms are not statistically significant, indicating that leftist and non-leftist councillors, as well as councillors with and without dependent children at home, respond similarly to the treatment. These analyses are exploratory and should be interpreted with caution.
7. To further explore heterogeneity in policy preferences, we tested whether treatment effects vary by gender, political party, and presence of dependent children (see Appendix Tables C.5–C.7). These subgroup analyses are exploratory and should be interpreted with caution given the number of comparisons conducted. The interaction terms for gender and dependent children are not statistically significant, indicating that men and women, as well as parents and non-parents, respond similarly to the treatment. By contrast, leftist councillors were significantly more likely than non-leftist councillors to support remote work, childcare, and parental leave policies under treatment. This suggests that political ideology influences responsiveness to family-friendly policies: leftist councillors are more likely to support measures such as remote work, childcare, and parental leave when presented with a council actively promoting them, likely because this reflects alignment with their values.
8. E.g., Cllr Sally Yalden, "Could Local Government Reorganisation reverse progress towards gender parity among councillors?", LGIU, 8 January 2026, <https://lgiu.org/blog-article/could-local-government-reorganisation-reverse-progress-towards-gender-parity-among-councillors/>

Acknowledgments

We thank Jessica C. Smith and three anonymous reviewers for valuable feedback on earlier versions of the manuscript.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

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